Blood and Brains

By Roger Guenveur Smith

INTRODUCTION

Slavery has been a part of nearly every civilization and has existed in one form or another since the beginning of time, yet today many people seem to believe slavery is just an ugly part of the past. Not so. Slavery persists today in a less obvious, more pervasive way. Inflation, energy costs, housing and health care are putting a strain on everyone in the lower echelons of America's class structure – the vast majority of these citizens are African American.. As life in the 21st century progresses, a harsh reality has become obvious for anyone willing to see. We remain slaves - Slaves manipulated by the capitalist, consumer economy, which uses poverty as a tool of suppression and punishment. The American dream of freedom and prosperity has been replaced by service and consumerism. The country wants nothing less than our Blood and Brains by Roger Guenveur Smith.

I am a fugitive slave
I live underneath the Hollywood Freeway
Or the Brooklyn Bridge
Somewhere
Under the Rainbow
My coalition kept warm
by blazing barrels of trash

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scraps from the cane fields
and the fast food establishments
I'm on the run
Up and down a basketball court
and into the bush
You can't touch me
I am a maroon
Chilling high above
the smog line
and the tourist enclaves
The North Star
visible every night
My guide into a Philly groove
The Delfonics
Soundtracks to my most intimate moments
Ain't no stopping me now
I'm on the move
Up the Chesapeake
and into the Mississippi
inventing jazz and blood plasma along the way
I'm wearing a hat
a brim
a new attitude
and I'm ready for a new century
so bring it on
serve it up with mush
crumbs
from the table of discontents
I'm going to the Great House Farm
O Yea
and I can't decide if I want dreads

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or an Afro
or a skinhead
or a conk
so I'm shopping for wigs
Do you have the Henry Box Brown look?
He was shipped North in a box
and wound up with a flat top
Henry Box Brown
I'm on the run
In a white Bronco disguised as an ex-football player
Through the streets of Virginia Beach
and into a boxing ring
battering my brother to death
grinning at the press conference
proclaiming victory
and misquoting some dead leader
I'm a movie star
gun at the ready
plastered on plantation walls
next to the malt liquor ads
Drunk
on my own infected blood
Strong
stronger than the jackass and the circus elephant that
get more respect than I do
No I'm not registered to vote
but still I'm running for office
For the Canadian border
For some hovel in South London
where I can make a living
a better living than I'm making now

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cutting cane
with this rusty machete:
My master is my father
My father my master
Note my resemblance to this wooden nickel
Isn't my grimace the same as his?
I whipped my overseer
Didn't you see it on *Cops?*
I whipped Rosa Parks
She forgave me
I know how to do
the Black Panther Stomp
and the Charleston
and don't forget the Texas Hop
Disguised myself as a tap dancer
Entertained on the White House lawn
All the while tapping the phone
and getting out the message
to the barbershops
and the Lodges
The Howard University School of Law
Never go outside
without wearing my root
tucked into my right Nike boot
I'm a fugitive slave
running in Hitler's Olympics
gold chains and medals dangling
on the cover of a box of Wheaties
constructing ships for my imminent departure moored in
the Harlem River
or Lake Michigan

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When it's frozen over
My kind of town
Quiet
No slave catchers in sight
Just a soft neon glow
from the *taquerias*
Someone wants to sell me a green card
I'm in the Grand Canyon
listening to Bob Marley tapes
Smoking the peace pipe
with Osceola and the Wild Tchoupitoulas
Jumping up at Mardi Gras
and carnival
and on the first and fifteenth of every month
I'm sitting on the dock of the bay
watching the luxury liners go by
and it's New Year's Eve
and they're playing the blues
and Public Enemy
and I'm trying desperately not to believe the hype
All I need is my Thorazine
I'm not a violent person
Just terribly misguided
I went into space and blew up
I went into hiding up your family tree:
Don't look now
I'm an American slave
and I've got my own sitcom
Millions of laughs per century
with no commercial interruption
I wear three-piece suits

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and penny loafers
I've read the classics
I've been to Yale
and I've been to jail
Trumped up charges
They gagged me
Then they made me a news anchor
on the Titanic
Reporting live from a disaster in progress S
wam to shore with Cuban refugees only to be shipped to Panama
where we swam the Canal
after we dug it
The Rio Grande
The Nile with Langston Hughes
Caught the mock slave auction
in Williamsburg
Took a couple of licks
just for old times' sake
Gave a couple
to show my versatility
Personally escorted Nelson Mandela throughout the fifty states
Showed him where the Civil War started and never ended
The Underground Railroad
upgraded for the 1990s
Let's just say it runs from here to there and it's not a straight path
I'm moving
to the beat

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of bare feet
Shackled and perfumed
Pedicured
for the front row patrons
who love public executions
Yeah I ran with Fred
Knew him from the projects
Even back in the day
He had his own talk show
Guests like Nat Turner
and Denmark Vesey
Theme song went:
Learning will spoil the best nigger in the world
So let's get spoiled y'all
That's how I learned my ABC
Wrote my first book
Gave my first lecture
Recorded my first platinum CD
Conferred with Dr. King
at the Lorraine Motel
Told him to duck
Now I'm at large
My portrait on the post office wall
and the cover of *Time* magazine
A tremendous reward for my capture
Because I'm the most valuable player
One of the world's great men of color
Taught Hendrix how to play "Foxy Lady" Yet invisible
in my Eleganza ensemble
My tuxedo
My butt-nakedness at Attica

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My tears frozen
in some rerun sequence
on somebody's telethon
I'm eating my pass to freedom
Once carefully forged
and now digested
My only meal for days
WILL WORK FOR FOOD
my latest poem
scrawled on Henry Brown's discarded box
A liquor company told me
I'm descended from great Kings and Queens: forty
ounces of black history anybody?
You can't catch me
I know all the black roads and alleys
The best restaurants
How to live high
on the hog
I invented chitlins and crack cocaine
A secret lab
behind where Thurgood Marshall plotted civil rights and
political casualties come to be consoled
Where the dismembered get stitched
And everything is everything
Doorman
to the best club in the world
where the passwords are
Freedom
Now
Changed my name

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From Bailey to Stanley to Johnson to Douglass to Ida B.
Wells
Plotted with John Brown
Narrowly escaped the noose myself
Still running
All those European tours
Applauded and lauded
till they mistook me for an Arab
Got hooked on heroin and bebop
Started my own import export concern
Got busted for trafficking in literacy
Still doing time on that charge
Never should have preached about
David or Goliath
or how we need to boycott Denny's
This is written by myself
in blood if necessary
No Westside abolitionist
furiously working the laptop
on my behalf
scripting my punch lines
and designing my wardrobe
This is written in my mother's milk
Stronger than any formula
or synthetic decongestant
My voice is my own
No Richard and Willie act here
I write my own music too
The only tune I've ever covered
was the "Star Spangled Banner"
1983 NBA All Star Game

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Remember?
I've gone from Jamestown
to Trenchtown
to Jonestown
Never did like Kool-Aid
Fought in every war invented and then some
Right now I'm fighting for the right
to peddle this knowledge
on this particular corner
at this particular time
Dime bags of truth, anybody?
Fugitive
In the jungles of Surinam
and the hills above South Central
awaiting an earthquake
or an insurrection:
whichever comes first
Meanwhile making myself heard
on the far end of the dial
in between
the shouts and screams
the grunts and sighs
the sirens and helicopters
Dogs
lapping at my scent
Chasing me since 1838
Up and down Malcolm X Boulevard
Somebody tell me
It's just a Spike Lee movie
Somebody tell me
why I just fired two rounds

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into my own reflection
like some Narcissus gone mad
I've read the classics
Remember?
Spray painting my name
any name
on any wall that will have me
Outlaw
Gangsta rappa
Ph.D.
My dissertation lies unread
Trampled underneath the crowd
as they file out of Madison Square Garden
or the unemployment office
or the 4th of July celebration
where they just hanged two niggers for sport
Still I rise
From this nightmare called history
Cold sweats
in my cardboard box
my concrete crib
my room without a view
Dreamless nights
and endless days
Punching this heavy bag
like Louis
or Ali
like James Brown at the Apollo:
Out of confusion
Out of bondage
Up from slavery

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Up from Maryland
Up from Mississippi
Up from the gutter
in which I'm lying right now
choking on my own filth
and the automotive exhaust
See me in your rearview mirror?
Now look into your future
Snap
into that virtual reality
Am I still preaching the gospel
on late night TV?
Pushing pancake batter?
Reading old slave narratives
as bedtime stories?
Putting America to sleep?
Fugitive
I've gone underground
Way underground
Burrowed underneath Mount Rushmore and Stone Mountain Georgia
Got an inventory of all Confederate flags and colored jockey statues
Closely monitoring the activities
of the brother
who took my mom's car keys on Crenshaw
and the brother
who put a knife to my lady's neck on Wilshire
and the brother
who pulled a gun on me
claiming to be an off-duty cop

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in search of a stolen bicycle
and the brothers
who stomped my friend to death
in front of the Hollywood Palladium
and laughed
Something about a black leather jacket
Are my references too obscure?
Can you follow my drift?
In the Atlantic?
In the Caribbean?
In the creek
in chapter four
of Frederick Douglass's *Native?*
In an instant
poor Denby
was no more
His mangled body sank
out of sight
and blood
and brains
marked the water
where he had stood
The deed was done by a religious overseer named Gore
Hell of a baptism
But still I have risen
To fight the negro breaker
Jim Crow
Naysayers
and doomsayers
Enemies within
Supremacists of every stripe

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My own self doubt
and suicidal tendencies:
You have seen
how a man was made a slave;
You shall see
how a slave was made a man
Armed with two fists
one mind
and a semi-colon
Dangerous
Devious
Made it to Tribeca in one day feeling as if I'd escaped a den of lions
One of the lucky ones I suppose
So many more to follow
So many more to lead the way: Now take me to the bridge
I'm ready.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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